

By harnessing the energy in sunlight, and using it to grow, green plants play a central role in life on Earth. They generate food for animals and other organisms, and often form their habitats as well. Some plants are small and simple, but they also include giant conifers, and a dazzling wealth of flowering species that have evolved a remarkable array of shapes and strategies for survival.



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**HORNWORTS •
LYCOPHYTES**

Hornworts are small plants, related to mosses, which produce spores from an elongated, horn-like structure. Lycophytes were previously thought to belong with the ferns, and include clubmosses.



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**FERNS AND
RELATIVES**

Ferns are the largest plants that reproduce with spores instead of seeds. Many are low-growing, but some form trees, which have trunks made of fibrous roots rather than wood.



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**CYCADS,
GINKGOS, AND
GNETOPHYTES**

These plants do not have flowers, but they do form seeds. Before flowering plants evolved, cycads formed an important part of the world's vegetation.



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CONIFERS

Although far fewer in species than flowering plants, conifers dominate the landscape in some parts of the world. All of them are trees or shrubs, and they typically form seeds in woody cones.



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**FLOWERING
PLANTS**

This is by far the largest group of living plants, making up the bulk of the world's vegetation. They all grow flowers – often inconspicuously – and spread by forming seeds.